

Auwa Instagram

Updated: 23 July 2026. Living document. Load when working on social media content, Instagram ads, or audience growth.

Where we are (15 July 2026)

Account: **@auwalife** at [instagram.com/auwalife](https://www.instagram.com/auwalife). **Followers: 2,667** (22 Jul; up from ~700 at the May restart — on plan; the arrival.md Phase 1 target was 2-3K by end June). Rieko kept the account posting through ~6 weeks (early June to mid-July) while Tom was away following his father's death, which is why the one compounding metric held.

What's working:

- **~£350 ad spend used so far** (well inside the £2K Year 1 budget). Blended cost-per-follower far under the £1 quality gate. Some promoted posts did very well.
- **Breakout post:** [instagram.com/p/DYchpYBse01](https://www.instagram.com/p/DYchpYBse01) — 4,000+ likes, 65 comments, ~200 shares, warm comments. Shares are the #1 algorithm signal, so this format travelled. **Study what made it work and repeat the format before inventing new ones.**
- **72 micro-seasons cadence:** Rieko now makes an illustration or short video every 5 days for the seasons, and is enjoying the rhythm. She's flagged these could be released later as a complete set (72 pieces) — a natural print/calendar/newsletter asset once the series is complete. This is also the obvious spine for a "quiet letter every five days" newsletter hook (see arrival.md capture gap).

Content pipeline: posts prepared and queued in `social/instagram/_scripts/schedule.txt` ; the planning view at auwa.life/instagram renders the schedule live from disk.

The gap: despite 2,667 followers + heavy Awwwards traffic, newsletter subs total only ~93 (baseline 12 book / 41 store / 38 app). Capture is the weak link, not audience growth. See arrival.md, and "The capture loop" below.

Attacking the gap (22 Jul 2026): two moves this session. (1) A proper **Meta lead-form ad** is now live for store signups — see "Meta lead ads — playbook + live campaign" under Paid advertising below; it's in review, don't touch for ~5 days, and the leads need pulling from Meta

into Resend. (2) Two site fixes that were quietly costing conversions: the あうわ **entrance loader was removed** (it made every cold visitor wait ~3s before the page appeared — worst for paid mobile traffic), and a **auwa.life/privacy page was created** (standard pre-launch policy, required for Meta lead forms; not lawyer-reviewed). Both deployed to production.

Content folders live under `social/instagram/<pillar>/<post>/` with the pillar prefixes `0-brand`, `1-book`, `2-store`, `3-journal`, `4-app`. Each post folder contains an `_post.txt` brief (caption, alt text, hashtags, notes) plus the images. The planning view at `auwa.life/instagram` (dev: `localhost:3003/instagram`) renders the schedule live from disk.

Strategy in one paragraph

Build an audience that joins for the **world** (philosophy, character, craft, Japan), not for the product. Sales come as a side-effect of trust, never as the headline. Post three times per week, mix Reels and carousels, hold pace for a year. Single-platform focus on Instagram until 5,000 followers; expand to TikTok reposts and YouTube depth content only after that bar is cleared.

The capture loop (how sign-ups, seasons, and the figure tie together)

Added 22 Jul 2026. This is the spine of the capture strategy. Any future session working on ads, the newsletter, the bio, or the sign-up page should keep this loop intact and consistent across every surface.

The problem it solves: 2,667 followers but only ~93 subscribers. Audience growth is fine; *capture* is the weak link. A follower is rented (the algorithm decides who sees you); a subscriber is owned (you reach them directly). The loop below turns the free content Rieko already makes into an owned, warm list of future buyers.

One asset, three surfaces. Rieko already draws one illustration or short video every five days for the 72 micro-seasons. That single asset feeds three places at once:

1. **The IG post** — the public, free gift. Grows reach and followers. No sign-up ask; it's a gift.
2. **The Quiet Letter email** — the same season, sent to the list every five days: one illustration, a few lines. This is the *reason to hand over an email*. Not a sales funnel; more of the world.

3. **The eventual 72-piece set** — once complete, a print/calendar asset and a natural product.

Two hooks, two jobs. Every sign-up ask combines them:

- **The figure giveaway is the spike.** Scarcity ("a chance to win our first-edition figure") drives a burst of sign-ups *today*.
- **The Quiet Letter is the baseline.** Ongoing value ("a quiet letter every five days") is why people are *still subscribed and still warm* in three months.
- Used together everywhere (teach the concept, then invite — see the ad playbook's comprehension principle): *"72 seasons a year, drawn by Rieko. A quiet letter, and a chance to win our first-edition figure."*

Where it's heading: a warm list of future buyers. The list is not vanity, and Auwa must make money. A subscriber who has received a beautiful letter every five days for months, and entered to win the figure, is the warmest possible buyer when the book pre-order and figure drop open in autumn. We build the audience *before* we need it, not scrambling at launch. The list is the commercial engine for the product launches.

Every capture surface points at the same offer. IG bio link, Meta lead-form ads, Stories link sticker, and the website sign-up all carry the identical Quiet Letter + giveaway framing. If a future session changes the offer in one place, change it everywhere — a split message across surfaces is why capture leaked in the first place.

The Gift Ethos

Everything Auwa posts should feel like a gift, not a sale. Brands that behave like businesses plateau on Instagram; brands that behave like contributions compound. Every post gives the reader something — a new word, a moment of beauty, a piece of craft knowledge, a reflection they want to hold. The commercial messaging (teaser signups, product launches, store openings) appears rarely and quietly, as a natural consequence of trust already built, never as the driver of content.

Touchstones: Kinfolk, The Marginalian, School of Life, Blackbird Spyplane. All gave freely for years before monetising lightly.

Tension to manage: "gift" is a feeling, not an identity. Auwa *is* a business. The posture is **a brand that behaves like a gift, and occasionally invites you to buy something we've made.** Giving sets the default. Selling is an exception earned by giving first.

Pillar priority (May 2026)

In order of weight in the current schedule and the next 10 weeks of posts:

1. **Book** (1-book) — the illustrated story universe. Heaviest pillar. Character animations from Rieko, book inside-N teasers, sketchbook process, book-as-object lifestyle shots, the four-book series statement.
 2. **Store** (2-store) — Auwa figures. First-edition launch is the year's commercial moment. Figure-in-setting shots, the edition reveal, the Blender process Reel.
 3. **Journal** (3-journal) — editorial carousels from auwa.life/journal articles. Rieko writes one article per fortnight, which yields one editorial slideshow for Instagram.
 4. **Brand** (0-brand) — atmospheric character pieces (kokoro, magical, face). Sparingly placed for tonal breath.
 5. **App** (4-app) — **deprioritised**. Two teasers already in the queue, but app promotion is held until the book/store audience is built. Don't add more app content for now.
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Three posts per week

A sustainable rhythm that wins by consistency, not volume. Five-a-week for three months underperforms three-a-week for fifty-two weeks. The algorithm punishes inconsistency more than it punishes low frequency.

Suggested weekly shape (adjust to the queue and the moment):

- **Mid-week Reel** (Tue/Wed) — character animation from Rieko, or process Reel (e.g. figure-blender). The growth driver.
- **Weekend slideshow** (Fri/Sat) — editorial carousel from a journal article, or a book teaser, or a store figure shot. Drives saves and DM-shares.
- **Sunday post** (atmospheric photo or single image) — quiet close to the week.

Plus **daily Stories** (1–3 slides). Stories are separate from the feed. Use interactive stickers (polls, sliders, question boxes) at least twice a week.

Content production rates

What's being produced on an ongoing basis:

Stream	Rate	What it yields
Editorial articles	1 per fortnight	1 editorial IG slideshow + 1 Story share
Character Reels	1 per week from Rieko	1 Reel (the growth driver)
Behind-the-scenes	Ongoing as it happens	Mostly Stories; the strongest get promoted to feed
Figure / book lifestyle shots	As assets are produced	Single-image feed posts

That's ~6 new pieces a month from these streams, comfortably feeding the 3-per-week cadence with material to spare. The queue currently has more than 10 weeks of content prepared, so the production rate above represents the **replenishment**, not the launch volume.

Algorithm priorities (2026)

In order of impact on reach:

1. **Sends/shares via DM** — the #1 ranking signal. Content people send to friends gets dramatically more reach.
2. **Watch-through rate on Reels** — watched to completion or replayed = major boost.
3. **Caption keywords** — IG's 2026 search reads captions semantically. Put words like *Auwa*, *Kokoro*, *Eko Maeda*, *picture book*, *Japanese awareness*, *illustrated story* naturally into prose.
4. **Carousels rival Reels for reach** — IG re-serves slides 2+ to users who didn't engage first time.

Hashtags increasingly behave as topic classifiers rather than discovery channels of their own. Three to five sharp tags outperform ten mixed ones. Don't repeat identical hashtag sets across many posts — the algorithm reads that as bot-pattern.

Image & Video Specs

Reels — 1080 × 1920 (9:16). 30–60s sweet spot for retention. MP4 H.264 30fps min. Cover crops to 1080 × 1350 in the feed grid, so design the cover with both crops in mind.

Stories — 1080 × 1920. 5–7 slides per sequence performs well; drop-off accelerates after slide 7. Interactive stickers heavily weighted.

Feed singles — 1080 × 1350 (4:5 portrait). Maximum screen real estate.

Feed carousels — 1080 × 1350. Up to 20 slides. All slides must be the same aspect ratio.

Profile photo — 500 × 500 minimum, circular crop. Auwa character (see Profile Setup below).

Editorial slideshow format

For each Journal article, a companion Instagram carousel turns editorial writing into swipeable grid content.

Template (5+ slides):

1. **Hero cover** — per-post decision:
 - Lead with `image-hero.jpg` (clean photo) when the **image** is the hook — atmospheric landscape, human moment, beautiful object. Examples: Yakushima cedars, Koya-san stone bridge, Shigefusa blade, washi maker's hands.
 - Lead with `image-hero-text.jpg` (typeset title) when the **concept** is the hook — an unfamiliar word or unique idea the reader needs to see named. Examples: Kokoro / Yaoyorozu no Kami, 72 Seasons.
 - Default: clean photo. Use the `Cover:` field in `_post.txt` to override per post.
2. **Pull quote** (`text-quote-dark` or `text-quote-light`) — short phrase, large serif. Make the viewer pause.
3. **Body photo** — one of the article's `image-*.jpg` body images.
4. **Pull quote** or additional body photo — varied typographic treatment from slide 2 if both are quotes.
5. **Close** (`text-close-dark` or `text-close-light`) — "Continue reading at [auwa.life/journal/\[slug\]](https://auwa.life/journal/[slug])". Quiet CTA.

Slides 3 to N-1 can mix body photos and pull quotes in whatever order serves the article. Up to 20 slides total; the strongest articles deserve 6–8.

Typography note: the typeset cover treatment (serif title centred, AUWA wordmark masthead-style above, Japanese underneath in lighter weight) sits at Cereal Magazine / Casa

BRUTUS tier. Not the Pinterest-infographic style that gets devalued.

Each article generates one slideshow. With one article per fortnight, that's ~25 slideshows per year.

Content ideas (vault + ongoing)

Ready to deploy now (existing vault)

- Japan photography (15+ years of trips)
- Rieko's illustrations and Auwa animations
- Fin DAC Auwa stencil session
- Craftsman photography from Monolise research trips
- Auwa story scenes from the books in progress
- Rieko drawing process time-lapses
- Sketchbook pages (the early-ideas set)

Ongoing production

- Auwa character animations (Runway, After Effects)
 - Craft ASMR clips (artisan hands, making processes)
 - Japan travel teases (temples, paths, seasonal moments)
 - Stories/polls ("Which emotion resonates today?")
 - Collaborations (Fin DAC collab post, Japanese culture accounts)
 - Kokoro quotes (text over illustration)
 - App demos and shareable card reveals (post-launch)
 - Store unboxing and craftsman spotlights (post-store launch)
 - Artisan spotlights (craftsman meets, workshop visits)
 - Silent walks (ambient video, no voiceover)
 - Seasonal rituals and wellness content
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Growth plan: 700 → 5,000

Phase 1 — Establish (weeks 1–4, posts 6–17)

Profile depth is the goal. Build the grid so a first-time visitor scans 9–12 tiles and understands what Auwa is.

- **Content focus:** universe-establishing posts first — 1-book/series , the character Reel 0-brand/kokoro , the first figure reveal 2-store/figure-1 . Sprinkle behind-the-scenes (1-book/sketches , 2-store/figure-blender).
- **Paid:** No follower-growth boosts yet — profile too sparse to convert. Optional Lead Form ads (£10/day) for store waitlist; small retargeting (£3–5/day) for past auwa.life visitors.
- **Engagement:** Reply to every comment. Engage genuinely on 10–15 relevant accounts daily (Japanese art, illustration, slow living, design culture, emotional intelligence).
- **Target:** 700 → 1,500 followers, 100–200 email signups.

Phase 2 — Amplify (weeks 5–8, posts 18–29)

Grid is deep enough. Start paid awareness on proven organic performers.

- **Content focus:** the story-led book moments (inside-9 Kokoro reveal, inside-10 Bluu memory). More figure shots. Continue 1 Reel/week from Rieko. Two editorial articles in this window.
- **Paid (~£800):** boost 1-book/series (£200), 2-store/figure-1 (£200), 0-brand/kokoro (£150), 1-book/sketches (£150), 4-app/teaser-2 (£100).
- **Engagement:** Fin DAC collab post (warm lead). Reach out to 5–10 complementary accounts (5K–50K followers) for collab posts.
- **Target:** 1,500 → 3,000 followers.

Phase 3 — Convert (weeks 9–12+, posts 30+)

Audience is built. Drive to product moments.

- **Content focus:** climactic book posts (inside-16 connection, inside-17 song). Figure edition reveal (figure-6). First product launches (book first edition + figure drop).
- **Paid (~£700–1,200):** boost 1-book/inside-9 , inside-16 , 2-store/figure-4 (vitrine), 2-store/figure-6 (edition). Retargeting for waitlist non-converters.
- **Target:** 3,000 → 5,000+ followers.

Expected outcome at £2,000 paid spend

1,500–3,000 new quality followers from paid, plus organic growth of another 1,000–2,000 via content + collabs. **Realistic Year 1 finish: 4,000–5,000 followers.** Paid amplifies the

floor, not the ceiling — content quality, the Fin DAC collab, daily Stories, and community DMs do the heaviest lifting.

Paid advertising (£2,000 Year 1 Budget)

When to start boosting

Wait until the profile has 12+ posts on the grid before running follower-growth boosts. With a sparse profile, ad-clicked visitors scroll for 3–7 seconds, see thin content, and leave. Same £100 typically converts at 10–25 followers on a 5-post account vs. 50–100 on a 15-post account.

What can run earlier than 12 posts:

- **Lead Form ads** — convert on the post + native IG form, not on profile depth. Add emails to the list. Anytime.
- **Retargeting** — past website visitors. Anytime, £3–5/day.

Meta lead ads — playbook + live campaign (22 Jul 2026)

This is now the primary lever against the capture gap (only ~91 newsletter subs despite 2.5K followers). A Lead Form ad collects the email *inside Instagram*, so it sidesteps the website loader/bounce problem entirely.

What the first attempt taught us (the failed boost, 20 Jul). A 1-day boost run from the Instagram app spent ~£19 and drove 421 site visits to auwa.life/store but produced only **3 signups**. Post-mortem from the Meta/Vercel/Resend stats:

- The IG-app "Boost" button forces **Advantage+ placements** (auto Facebook + Audience Network) and a **traffic / "website visits" objective**. It optimises for the *cheapest click*, not the signup. Cost per visit was £0.05 — a red flag, not a bargain.
- Result: top referrer was `m.facebook.com` (426), not Instagram; geography was France 26% / Malaysia 26% / India — cheap-click junk, not the intended English audience. The vertical Reel was shown mostly on Facebook feed, cropped and out of context.
- Rieko had picked UK + US + France + Malaysia (Malaysia on a hunch it's wealthy). France + Malaysia were the leak. **Lesson: for an English brand, start UK + US only.**

The correct setup (built 22 Jul, use this as the template):

- Build in **Ads Manager on desktop** (adsmanager.facebook.com), NOT the IG-app Boost button. Boost can't turn off Advantage+ placements or set a Leads objective.
- Ad account: run under the **Auwa Limited** business portfolio, not Rieko's personal account (company owns the history/billing). Note: moving Rieko's old personal ad account in was blocked ("no payment made yet"), so a **new ad account was created** under Auwa Limited with the company card. The old personal-account boosts stay where they are.
- Objective: **Leads**. Conversion location: **Instant forms** (not Website — no pixel needed, and it dodges the site entirely).
- Budget: **Campaign budget, £5/day** for a clean test. Advantage+ leads campaign toggle can stay on for the *campaign*, but placements must be manual.
- Placements: **Manual → Instagram only**. Critically, **untick "Allow limited spending to excluded placements"** — left ticked, Meta leaks ~5%/placement back onto Facebook et al.
- Audience: **UK + US only** (locations are a hard cap even with Advantage+ audience on). Left age/gender default.
- Creative: **Use existing post → Instagram tab**, the breakout animation reel (Everything holds a Kokoro, post ID 17886841077516285, 17 May 2026, = [instagram.com/p/DYchpYBse01](https://www.instagram.com/p/DYchpYBse01)). Note: Ads Manager's post-picker shows stale/low engagement counts (showed 113 vs the real 4.5K) — ignore it, the live ad carries the real numbers.
- Instant form: type **More volume; email only** (delete name field); intro headline "Join the Auwa list" + the figure-giveaway hook; data-use disclosure line is **required** (name the email use + unsubscribe); completion screen "We'll be in touch when it's time to launch, and if you've been selected for the first-edition Auwa figure giveaway." Flexible form delivery **Off** for a clean first test.
- Privacy policy: Meta requires a live URL. Built **auwa.life/privacy** this session (standard pre-launch policy, deployed; NOT lawyer-reviewed — revisit before scaling / before app+store launch).

Creative choice — why the breakout character reel, NOT a store-tailored video.

Important nuance: the 20 Jul failed boost *did* use a purpose-built store video (the multi-scene one: characters, lifetime objects, app, book, "sign up at auwa.life/store"). We did **not** make a new tailored store creative this session. We deliberately reused the beautiful **Auwa-character animation reel** (DYchpYBse01) instead — a video that isn't about the store per se — now carrying a "Sign up" CTA + Instant Form under it. Reasoning:

- It's the single best organic performer (4.5K likes, 715 saves, 145 shares). Shares are the #1 algorithm signal and saves signal deep resonance, so it earns cheaper, warmer delivery and

puts visible **social proof** on the ad. A proven winner beats an unproven creative.

- The tailored store video has never shown that pull, and its one live test (the boost) *failed* — though that failure was targeting/objective, not proof the creative is bad.
- With an **Instant Form**, the video's only job is to stop the scroll and build affinity for Auwa; the form's headline + figure-giveaway hook carries the actual store ask. A film people love + a clear form beats a store-explainer nobody saved.
- **Known tradeoff / next test:** the character reel isn't store-specific, so purchase/signup intent is softer than a store-tailored creative would prime. Once this has data, **A/B the tailored store video against the character reel** to see which converts cheaper per signup.

Note on the loader fix: removing the あうわ loader helps the **website** capture route (and any future "send to auwa.life" ads), but this Instant-Form campaign bypasses the site entirely, so the two fixes are complementary, not the same lever. The loader was part of *why the first campaign converted so poorly* (junk traffic hitting a 3-second gate); the lead form sidesteps that whole problem.

Live campaign: Auwa Signups – Store / ad set New Leads ad set / form Auwa Store Waitlist – 22 Jul. Published 22 Jul 2026, in review. £5/day, UK+US, IG-only, the breakout character reel.

NEXT SESSION — what to do:

1. **Do not touch it for ~5 days.** Every edit resets Meta's learning. Judge on **cost per lead**, not likes/clicks. Working = cost-per-signup under ~£2 (see Quality signal below).
2. **Retrieve the leads → Resend.** Signups sit inside Meta, they do NOT auto-flow to Resend. Manual route: Ads Manager → the form → "retrieve leads" → download CSV → import into Resend (Audience → Add contacts → tag **Store Waitlist**). Do this the first time *with* Tom.
3. **Better: automate delivery.** The form's "Automated lead delivery → Google Sheets" option drops leads into a sheet in real time; from there a connector (or a scheduled import) into Resend removes the manual CSV step. Set up if the ad performs.
4. If it works, consider turning Flexible form delivery **On + Optimised** and scaling budget slowly; if cost-per-lead is 3–5× the target, stop and rethink the creative/offer, don't rescue it.

Day-1 result (23 Jul 2026). First full day at £5/day returned **5 leads at £0.94 each** (£4.71 spent) — comfortably under the £2 cost-per-lead gate, and a different universe from the 20 Jul boost (~£19 for 3 real site signups amid junk geography). The Ads Manager / Leads / Instant-Form / IG-only / UK+US setup worked as predicted. Caveats carried forward:

- Day one, n=5, still in Meta's learning phase — directional only, left untouched (judge on the full ~5-day run).
- **Instant-form leads are structurally softer-intent than website signups** (Meta pre-fills the email, one-tap submit), so £0.94 here is not equivalent to a £0.94 website signup. Cost-per-lead is only half the verdict; lead *quality* is the other half and can't be read until the Quiet Letter is actually sending (opens, figure click-through).
- Video creative: **55% hook rate** (strong scroll-stop) but **7.61% hold / 8s average** on a 47s film — the message lands in the first ~10s and almost everyone drops after. For a lead form that's fine (they tap the form, not the ending), but cut a **10–15s version** for the B/C tests rather than paying to serve 47s nobody watches.
- Demographics skewed ~**80% women, mostly 45–65+**. Read as on-brand (the craft / gift-buyer, Kinfolk/Goop skew), not a red flag; watch whether they click the figure. Older than the "design-conscious, Japan-interested" profile in the plan, but one day of data doesn't warrant touching targeting.
- Two same-day website signups were **NOT attributed to the ad** — the Instant Form bypasses the site, so at most a trickle came via the completion-screen "Visit auwa.life" button. Roughly organic baseline.
- **The bottleneck now is not ad settings, it's the Quiet Letter send.** Until leads are pulled into Resend and the letter is reaching them, each lead bought is unmeasurable and cooling. Banking the value = retrieve leads → Resend (tag Store Waitlist) + confirm the letter sends.

Messaging decision (23 Jul 2026). The live ad (Ad A) is **giveaway-only** and deliberately does **not** name the 72 seasons or the "Quiet Letter" — Tom's call is to not commit to that framing in public copy until the letters are genuinely sending. Consequence: the "teach 72 first / every capture surface carries the identical offer" doctrine (see "The capture loop" and the combined-hook copy below) is **aspirational, not yet in force** — surfaces are allowed to diverge for now. The journal signup card ("A letter, and a gift." / seasonal essays, craftsman stories, figure giveaway) intentionally does **not** align with the ad, and Tom is happy with it as a general-newsletter + giveaway ask. Revisit the combined-hook-everywhere standard only once the Quiet Letter send cadence is actually live.

Creative + offer test plan (the three ads)

Structured so each test isolates ONE variable. £5/day each; let every ad sit its full ~5–7 days untouched (edits reset Meta's learning). At this budget the signal is directional, not statistically clean — read cost-per-lead first, then lead *quality* (Quiet Letter opens, figure click-through) once the letter is sending. Lead count is the vanity metric.

- **Ad A — baseline (running from 22 Jul):** Character reel (DYchpYBse01) + **giveaway-only** form ("Join the Auwa list" + figure-giveaway hook). The existing live campaign.
- **Ad B — offer test:** Character reel + **combined Quiet Letter** + **giveaway** form (copy below). Same creative as A, so **B vs A isolates the OFFER** — does naming the Quiet Letter beat a plain giveaway ask?
- **Ad C — creative test:** Store video + **combined Quiet Letter** + **giveaway** form. Same offer as B, so **C vs B isolates the CREATIVE** — does the store-tailored video beat the character reel?

Sequencing: let A finish its run, then launch **B and C together** (same time window removes day-of-week / seasonality confounds from the creative comparison). Going forward the **combined hook is the standard**; the giveaway-only form (A) exists only as the baseline to beat.

Prediction to read against: the character reel likely pulls *cheaper but softer-intent* leads (people love it, strong social proof); the store video *fewer but higher-intent* ones. Winner = lowest cost per *quality* lead, judged after the Quiet Letter starts sending.

Lead-form copy — the combined hook (use for Ad B, Ad C, and every sign-up surface)

Auwa brand voice, no em dashes, email-only form. This is the canonical wording; keep it identical across the ad form, IG bio, Stories sticker, and website sign-up (see "The capture loop").

Comprehension principle (learned 22 Jul 2026): never say "every five days" or "the season turns" *without teaching the 72-seasons concept in the same breath*. The average UK/US reader doesn't know the Japanese year has 72 micro-seasons, so a bare "a letter every five days" reads as confusing (seasons don't change every five days) or spammy (why so often). Named, "the year has 72 seasons" is a charming scroll-stopper and the five-day cadence flips into "a series worth collecting." Teach, then invite. Note: the "never show the number 72" rule is an *app-UX* rule only; in marketing, the 72 seasons is a named asset and a hook.

Intro

- **Headline:** The year has 72 seasons
- **Description:** In Japan, the year turns not four times but seventy-two, each season about five days long. Rieko draws every one. Join the letter to receive them, and a chance to win our first-edition Auwa figure.

Question: email only (delete the name field).

Data-use disclaimer (Meta requires it): We'll use your email to send the Auwa letter and occasional news about the figure and book. Unsubscribe anytime. See our privacy policy at auwa.life/privacy.

Completion screen

- **Headline:** Welcome. The next season is on its way.
- **Description:** The seasons turn every five days, and we'll send each one as Rieko draws it. If you're drawn for the first-edition figure, we'll be in touch.
- **Button:** Visit auwa.life → <https://auwa.life>

Reusable one-liner (bio, Stories sticker, website — identical everywhere): 72 seasons a year, drawn by Rieko. A quiet letter, and a chance to win our first-edition figure.

Division of labour: the **giveaway is the acquisition hook** (converts the scroller today); the **Quiet Letter is the retention reason** (why they stay warm for months). Don't ask the letter to do the acquiring alone. And the letter must always be a *distinct, slightly deeper* experience than the IG caption (the season's name, a longer line, a note from Rieko, members-only early access), never a copy-paste of the post, or there's no reason to be on the list. See "The capture loop" for why the medium itself (a calm inbox ritual vs a fragmenting feed) is the on-brand core of its value.

Budget pacing

£15–25/day over 2–3 months. Algorithm needs time to optimise. Avoid £50/day for one month.

Boost shortlist

See Phase 2 and Phase 3 above for the specific posts and allocation. In short: lean on **series**, **figure-1**, **kokoro**, **sketches**, **inside-9**, **figure-4**, **figure-6**, **inside-16**.

Don't boost **figure-7** (the meditating maybe-variant) — that post earns its value from comment-volume signal, which paid would distort.

Check organic before boosting

Always look at a post's organic performance at 48–72 hours before deciding to boost it:

- 500 reach + >5% engagement → strong boost candidate
- 100–500 reach + 2–4% engagement → moderate; boost the best of these
- <100 reach + <1% engagement → don't boost. The post is the problem; reallocate.

Quality signal

Cost-per-follower under £1 + cost-per-signup under £2 = working. 3–5× higher = stop and reallocate. Don't try to rescue a non-converting boost.

Profile setup

- **Name field:** "Auwa | Japanese Awareness Practice" (searchable, keyword-rich)
 - **Bio:** Lead with what it IS. "Japanese philosophical awareness applied to modern life. Illustrated stories, an awareness practice app, and a craftsman store. auwa.life launching 2026." Minimal emoji.
 - **Category:** Art / Health & Beauty
 - **Profile photo:** **Auwa character**, not the wordmark. At 110px circular crop, the character (luminous form, two black eyes) is instantly identifiable; the "A" wordmark reads as any boutique brand. The character is the strongest recognition signal in every IG discovery surface. The "A" wordmark belongs on the website header and project labels, not the IG avatar. Revisit at ~50K+ followers if a confident-minimal switch ever feels earned.
 - **Highlights (4–6):** Universe, Kokoro, Seasons, Process, Press — custom covers in brand colours.
 - **Link:** native 5-link feature pointing to auwa.life and selected sub-paths (/book, /store, /journal).
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Hashtag strategy

3–5 highly relevant tags per post, not 10 mixed. The 2026 algorithm reads caption keywords semantically; hashtags are topic classifiers, not discovery channels in themselves.

Per post:

- 1–2 broad (500K–5M posts): #japanesephilosophy, #emotionalintelligence
- 1–2 mid-range (50K–500K): #picturebooks, #designertoy, #japaneseart

- 1–2 niche / branded: #auwa, #kokoro

Avoid:

- Identical hashtag sets across posts (algorithm flags this as spam pattern)
- Generic mood tags alone (#vibes, #aesthetic)
- Banned or restricted tags (check before using)
- Competitor brand tags (#kaws, #labubu) — reads opportunistic and may suppress reach

Caption keywords matter more than hashtags. Let *Auwa*, *Kokoro*, *Eko Maeda*, *picture book*, *Japanese awareness*, *illustrated story* appear naturally in the prose.

Best posting times (UK)

- **Weekdays:** 7:00–8:30 AM (morning scroll), 12:00–1:00 PM (lunch), 7:00–9:00 PM (evening)
 - **Sunday:** 10:00 AM–12:00 PM (lifestyle/wellness performs well)
 - **Japan overlap:** 7–8 AM UK = 3–4 PM Japan. Morning posts hit both audiences.
 - Refine with Instagram Insights once audience data accumulates.
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Key metrics to track

- **Follower growth rate** (weekly)
 - **Reach per post** (especially non-follower reach)
 - **Shares/sends via DM** (the #1 algorithm signal)
 - **Saves** (high-value content indicator)
 - **Email signups from Instagram** (waitlist conversions)
 - **Engagement rate** (likes + comments + saves + shares / reach)
 - **Cost-per-follower and cost-per-signup** on boosted posts
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Photography & image workflow

Tom's credentials: Published photographer. Japan photography has 17M+ views on Unsplash and has been used by Condé Nast Traveler, Vogue, WEF, Travel + Leisure, TimeOut, and Culture

Trip. 15+ years of Japan photography provides a deep content vault.

Pipeline:

- Japan travel catalogue (temples, seasonal landscapes, street scenes, food culture) → Seasonal Living pillar
- Craftsman photography from Monolise research trips → Behind the Kokoro / store spotlights
- Rieko's illustration process captures → Behind the Kokoro pillar
- AI-assisted image standardisation for store products (Remove.bg, Claude Vision → consistent white backgrounds)
- MidJourney + Rieko refinement for Auwa character content → Kokoro Reveal pillar

Tools: Lightroom for photography. Remove.bg or Claude Vision for product background removal. Figma for card layouts, carousel templates, and Story templates. Canva as fallback for quick social graphics.

Expansion (post-5K)

- **TikTok:** Repurpose best-performing Instagram Reels. Same content, different platform. Low effort.
 - **YouTube:** Original depth content. Craftsman making videos (30–45 min ASMR), Japan travel, philosophy deep-dives, interviews. Bi-weekly uploads. The long-term authority-building channel.
 - **Podcast appearances:** Pitch wellness, Japan culture, design, and EQ podcasts after 5K as social proof.
 - **App promotion:** Once book + store audience is established (potentially Q3 2026 or later), reintroduce app teasers and reveals.
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Quick-reference checklist

For the next 12 weeks of launch:

1. **Cadence:** 3 posts per week. Don't deviate up or down for at least a year.
2. **Pillar weighting:** Book + Store + Journal. App on hold.

3. **Boost timing:** Wait until 12+ posts before growth boosts. Lead Form and retargeting ads can run earlier.
4. **Cover treatment:** Per-post decision via **Cover:** field. Default: clean photo. Use typeset title when the concept is the hook.
5. **Hashtags:** 3–5 sharp tags per post. Vary the tail; don't repeat identical sets.
6. **Avatar:** Auwa character, not the wordmark.
7. **First comment:** always within 5 minutes of publishing.
8. **Check organic performance** at 48–72h before boosting any post.
9. **No app posts** in the schedule for now.
10. **Single-platform:** Instagram only until 5K. No TikTok cross-posting yet.